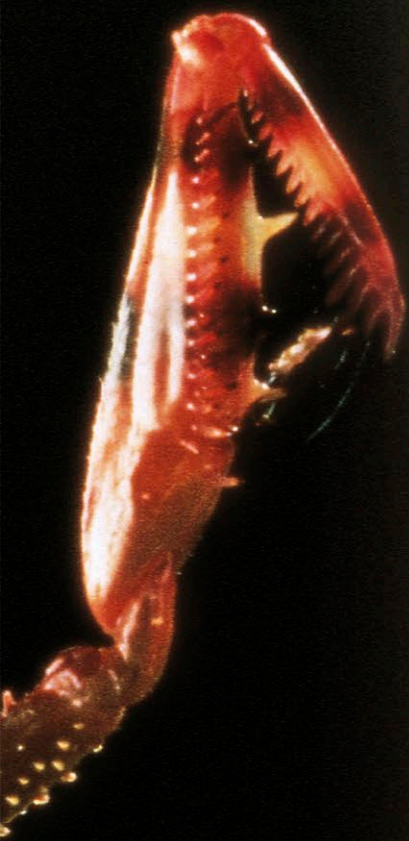


THREAT DISPLAY

When disturbed, mantids like this flower mantid, *Creobotra elegans*, often rear up into a defensive pose to display their vivid coloration. In addition to using its excellent eyesight, the mantid avoids attack from bats by using an ultrasonic ear on the thorax between the middle legs.

**Order Mantodea****Mantids**

The common name "praying" mantid is derived from the distinctive way in which mantids hold their front legs up and together, as if in prayer. Although variable in shape, mantids are distinguished by their triangular heads and large eyes—they are the only insects able to turn their head around to look behind them—and an elongated prothorax with the front pair of legs distinctively modified for catching live prey. Most mantids are diurnal and eat a large range of arthropods and, occasionally, even vertebrates such as frogs and lizards. Mantids reproduce by laying eggs in a papery or foamlike egg case, which, in some species, is guarded by the female. There are over 2,300 species.

Family Hymenopodidae**Flower mantids**

Occurrence 290 spp. in tropical regions, all around the world except Australia; on a wide variety of vegetation



Vivid coloration, including bright reds and greens (see left), allows these species to blend in perfectly with the plants on which they rest, awaiting the arrival of prey. Some parts of the body, such as the legs, often have broad extensions

that resemble leaves. The forewings of flower mantids may have colored bands or spirals, or circular marks that look like eyespots. In some species, the colored markings on the front wings can be asymmetrical. The wings of the female flower mantid are sometimes shorter than those of the male. Young nymphs are immediately predatory and are able to tackle prey as soon as their cuticles have hardened. As well as having an ultrasonic ear, used to detect predators, some species have a second ear that is responsive to much lower frequencies, but its function is unknown.

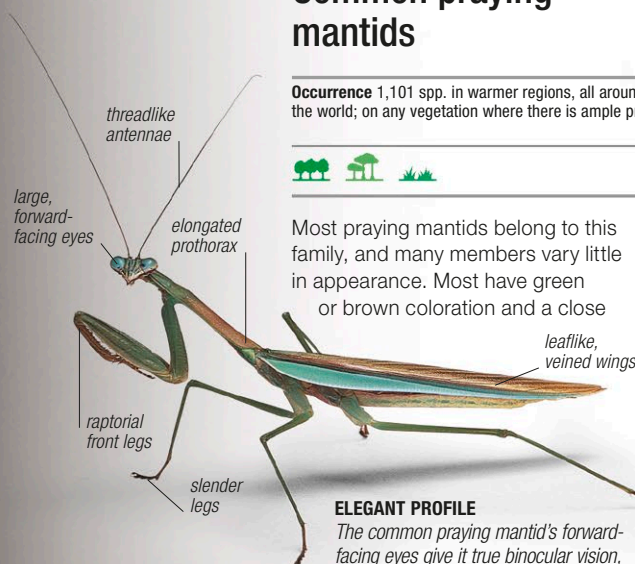
Family Mantidae**Common praying mantids**

Occurrence 1,101 spp. in warmer regions, all around the world; on any vegetation where there is ample prey

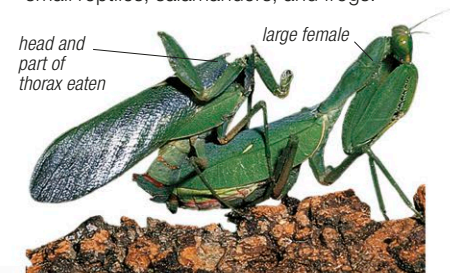


Most praying mantids belong to this family, and many members vary little in appearance. Most have green or brown coloration and a close

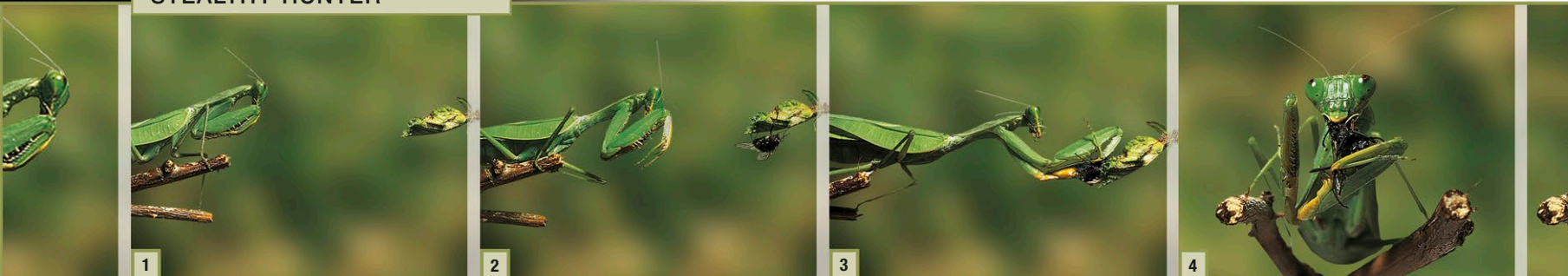
resemblance to leaves and twigs. Unlike families such as the flower mantids, the wings of common praying mantids are seldom patterned, although they may have wingspots. Females often have smaller wings than males, and some lack wings entirely. Some species of common praying mantids can grow up to 6 in (15 cm) in length, and the larger species are known to prey on small reptiles, salamanders, and frogs.

**ELEGANT PROFILE**

The common praying mantid's forward-facing eyes give it true binocular vision, allowing it to calculate distances accurately. This ability, together with its extendable front legs, makes it an effective hunter.

**DANGEROUS ENCOUNTERS**

Female common praying mantids are famed for eating the male after mating (see above). However, although mating can be dangerous for smaller individuals, males are usually cautious and seldom get eaten by their partner in the wild.

STEALTHY HUNTER**LYING IN WAIT**

The mantid lies patiently in wait for a potential meal. Perching on the end of a stick, forelegs together, it focuses on a likely landing site for prey.

THE POUNCE

As an unsuspecting fly comes within range, the mantid acts quickly. It launches itself at its victim, lunging forward and reaching out its long forelegs.

THE CAPTURE

At full stretch, the mantid seizes and impales its victim with its spiky legs before it is even aware of the mantid's presence.

ALL OVER IN SECONDS

Clasped in a strong grip, the helpless fly has no means of escape. Having retreated back to its stick, the mantid begins to eat its prey.